



not have as many supporters as one might have expected, given Birmingham's demographics.

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Like India, another favourite, England, also got off to a strong start. Riding on opener Danni Wyatt-Hodge's 62-ball 105 not out, the host made 219 for one, the highest score in the tournament's history, and romped home by 87 runs.

Cricket administrators believe an England triumph would be a big boost to the women's game in the country. Counties like Warwickshire, whose home ground is Edgbaston, are investing heavily in women's cricket. James Thomas (**pic, above**), who took over at Warwickshire as performance director from Gavin Larsen, a former New Zealand seamer and current selection manager of the Kiwi men's team, believes the women's game has the potential to grow further.

Thomas also has an interesting background. He moved to Warwickshire after serving as director of performance services at Manchester City Football Club. He has also worked in judo, gymnastics,

rugby and athletics. "Cricket is a new, fresh challenge for me," he tells me. "I think cricket will get a boost with the Olympic Games in Los Angeles. The Olympics after that is going to be hosted by Brisbane, and that should help too, as cricket is big in Australia."

Edgbaston is already looking forward to the Test against Australia next summer.

Matthew Joule, Head of Media & Communications at Warwickshire County Cricket Club, says construction of the new hotel inside the stadium will be completed by then. "It will be a value addition to the ground," he says.

"We will have 146 rooms, the half of which will have a view to the cricket on the ground."

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Back to football once again.

Larry Adeyemo (**pic, below**) is an engineer with a railway company here, but he was once an aspiring footballer who had shown promise at school. His mother, however, wanted him to become a doctor or an engineer.

"Footballers are lazy

Theatrical flourish: The cast of *Wicked* brings a touch of Broadway magic to the opening ceremony ahead of the ICC Women's T20 World Cup clash between England and Sri Lanka at Edgbaston in Birmingham.

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people," she used to tell him. "Now she is taking my kids to football. Her views on the game have changed. And my son has represented Britain in powerlifting."

Larry, who lives in London, is hopeful of a good showing from England at the football World Cup, especially with Thomas Tuchel as coach. He smiles broadly when you tell him that you interviewed Tuchel at an ayurvedic centre near Thrissur in Kerala a month after he parted ways with Chelsea.

That was the first time Tuchel had spoken publicly about his departure from Chelsea.

Larry has an Indian connection too. He was born in Chennai when his father, a Nigerian, was working in India as an engineer. "My father and I have been planning to come to India for a long time," he says. "Maybe later this year."

